

# APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



# Conflict Resolution

## Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Conflict Resolution competence of the APM Project Management Qualification.

This section will enable you to gain an understanding of different sources of conflict that could arise during the project life cycle, as well as different approaches to resolution that would be appropriate, based on the specific circumstances.

## Learning objective and outcomes

### Learning objective:

11. Understand conflict resolution as the ability to identify and address differences between individuals and/or interest groups.

### By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

11a) Know the sources of conflict within a project.

11b) Understand that conflict can have both positive and negative impacts within a project.

11c) Know ways in which conflict can be addressed in different situations (such as Thomas Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument).

## Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1 - 2 hours to complete.

## Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Conflict Resolution:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition, 3.1.5 Conflict Resolution.
- APM Learning Module, Managing and resolving conflicts:  
<https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/apm-learning/>
- APM A project professional's guide to conflict management and resolution:  
<https://www.apm.org.uk/v2/media/1yxg4klg/a-project-professional-s-guide-to-conflict-management-and-resolution.pdf>
- APM Blog Why conflict might not (always) be a bad thing for your project team:  
<https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/why-conflict-might-not-always-be-a-bad-thing-for-your-project-team/>

## Overview

Conflict is when two or more parties have a differing opinion or attitude towards something or someone. There can be many sources of conflict between stakeholders throughout the life cycle of any project.

Typically, conflict arises in a project when differences in opinions or opposing attitudes between stakeholders aren't easily reconciled or haven't been effectively managed.

## Sources of Conflict

This table shows some potential sources of conflict categorised by project phase.

| Phase                       | Conflict Source                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Concept</b>              | Securing funding, business case approval or ongoing support for the project.<br><br>Balancing stakeholder influences and agreeing high-level scope for the project.                                   |
| <b>Definition</b>           | Alignment of scope to project budget and priorities.<br><br>Agreeing resource plan and securing resources for the project.<br><br>Establishing the various components of the project management plan. |
| <b>Deployment</b>           | Maintaining resource availability and commitment.<br><br>Deadlines not being met, or progress not as expected.<br><br>Agreed plan, processes or methods not being followed.                           |
| <b>Transition</b>           | Acceptance criteria not met.<br><br>End-user expectations not achieved.                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Adoption</b>             | Outputs not adopted as intended by BAU.                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Benefits Realisation</b> | Agreement of measurement and realisation.                                                                                                                                                             |

## Positive vs. Negative

Although conflict can commonly be perceived as negative or destructive, it can also allow stakeholders to identify and address differences that could affect the success of the project's objectives.

Conflict may add value in the following ways:

- The facilitation of open conversations to allow debate and discussion.
- Allow the expression of feelings and agendas.
- Enable clarity of direction.

Ignoring conflict and those involved is never a productive way of ensuring the success of any project.

## Addressing Conflict

There are several methods and models that can be used to address conflict to achieve a successful and productive outcome.

One such model is the Thomas Kilmann model which encourages people to think about conflict using two dimensions:

- The desire to achieve one's own objectives.
- The desire to help others achieve their objectives.

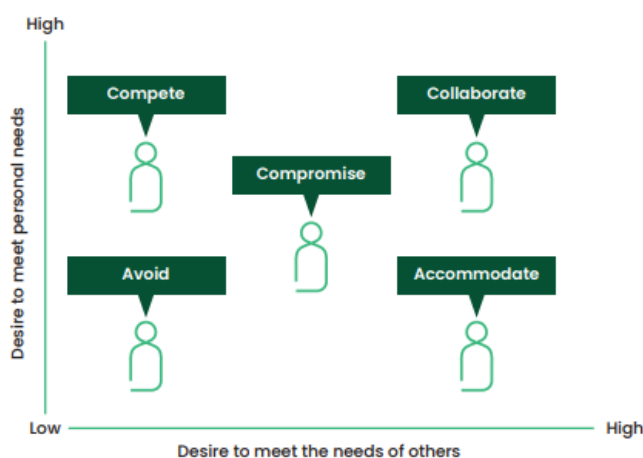


Figure adapted/modified from the TKI Conflict Model, copyright © Kilmann Diagnostics LLC, 2009-2023. All rights reserved. Original figure is available at: <http://www.kilmanndiagnostics.com/overview-thomas-kilmann-conflict-mode-instrument-tki>. Reproduced with permission. © Kilmann Diagnostics LLC, 2009.

This model's five conflict modes are:

**1. Compete      'I win, you lose'**

Quick solution or decision is necessary.

Emergencies occur or unpopular decisions need to be made.

Issues with a right and wrong solution.

**2. Avoid      'I lose, you lose'**

Issue is small or more important issues are pressing.

Potential disruption outweighs the benefit of resolving.

Want to avoid an overt disagreement.

**3. Compromise      'We both half win and half lose'**

When goals are important, but solutions are required under time pressure.

Through negotiation, parties find a mutually agreeable solution.

No one wins or loses; concessions are made to reach a middle ground.

**4. Collaborate      'I win, you win'**

Time required to explore concerns and find a consensus.

Focused on developing strong relationships.

Win-win approach through sharing of ideas and information to consider insights from different perspectives.

**5. Accommodate      'I lose, you win'**

Relationship is more important than the situation.

Maintain stability and cooperation.

To show reasonableness and to learn and let others learn through trying.

## Resolving Conflict

Resolving conflicts can be complicated because the individual circumstances can vary so much, but some important things to remember are:

- Anticipate conflicts happening – different people will have different opinions and desired outcomes, so always anticipate that there will be some form of conflict during any project.
- Don't ignore a conflict – it won't just go away, so ensure that you address it.
- Think about a resolution – avoid laying blame and instead look for a solution that will benefit the majority and the project itself.
- Encourage discussions – open and honest dialogue will always help to allow people to see each other's perspectives and allow for more practical and pragmatic solutions.
- Be a facilitator – encourage people to talk through their concerns and opinions and ask questions to help them explore potential resolutions.

- Keep conversations neutral – using neutral tone, language and body language can ensure less defensiveness and more communication.

In addition, it is important to remember that sometimes other parties that are external to the conflict may be required to resolve it and prevent it from further escalation.

Clear protocols are needed within a project to ensure, when conflict does escalate, that it is resolved in line with the project's delivery and governance.

**Scenario One:**

You've shared your business case for the 'Snappy Appy' renovation project to the senior leadership team and it has widely been received very positively.

However, you have heard murmurings that Alva, the Head of Sales doesn't believe that your business case is very comprehensive and has concerns around your ability to manage a project of this scale effectively.

**Where do you think this conflict comes from for Alva and what do you think is driving their concerns?**

**(You may find it useful to reference Alva's persona description as part of the Case Study)**

**Scenario Two:**

Alva's main concern about the handling and management of the renovation project is about the organisation's growing customer base.

They are always striving to do whatever it takes to maintain a strong customer relationship and will prioritise the delivery of product over most other things.

Although you are disappointed that they have not come to you directly with these concerns, you know that they normally have the best of intentions for both the company and its staff.

You know that you are going to have to have a conversation with Alva about their concerns, but you want to ensure that it is a constructive one driven by practicality and solutions, rather than negativity.

**What are some of the positive ways that Alva's concerns can be explored as part of the project?**

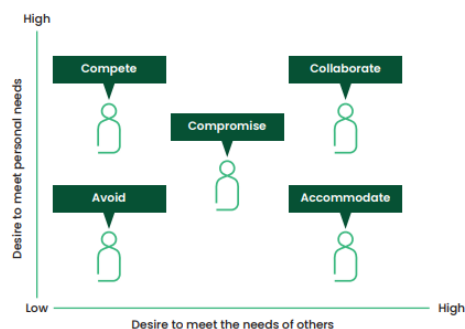
**What solutions could you offer to Alva to help mitigate her concerns about the impact on customers?**

**Scenario Three:**

Now that you have explored the positive aspects of Alva's concerns and thought of some solutions, it's time to present them.

Conflict resolution is always a factor to consider in project management and you know that it's not just about what you say, but how, when and where you say it.

**Using the Thomas Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument, where would you plot the conflict with Alva?**



**What is the most effective way to address this conflict with Alva?**

**Remember to consider the method, the location, the tone and body language as part of your answer.**

**Should any other parties be involved? Why/why not?**

## Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Conflict Resolution section:

- Considering each of the phases of a project and the potential sources of conflict in each, which stakeholders could be involved?
- How might conflict add value to project delivery?
- How can governance be used to support conflict resolution?
- What are some of the different ways that conflict can be addressed and in which situations would they be most appropriate to use?
- What other models of conflict resolution could be used in addition to Thomas Kilmann? What are the benefits of these different models?

## Exam practice questions

**11.1** Which of the following is a source of conflict which you would expect to see in the Definition phase of a project?

(1 mark)

- a. A dispute between the Business as Usual team and the project team about achievement of the project outcome.
- b. A disagreement over how to resolve an issue with supplier underperformance.
- c. Interpersonal friction in the team caused by a difference in background and experience.
- d. Challenge from a stakeholder regarding the quality of a project deliverable and whether it has met the project requirements.

**11.2** Which factors are negative impacts of conflict?

(1 mark)

- 1. Disagreement may lead to scope creep.
- 2. Disagreement may diffuse more serious conflicts.
- 3. Disagreement may lead to lower staff morale.
- 4. Disagreement may stimulate a search for new resolutions.
- 5. Disagreement may surface new project risks.
- 6. Disagreement may divert management time.

Select the correct combination of statements:

- a. 1 & 2
- b. 3 & 6
- c. 2 & 5
- d. 4 & 5

**11.3** When dealing with conflict, the Thomas Kilman model can be used to assess an individual's response to conflict.

Which of the following involves high assertiveness and high cooperativeness?

(1 mark)

- a. Compromising
- b. Accommodating
- c. Collaborating
- d. Competing

**11.4** You are leading a project to decide the future of your company website and are in the requirements gathering phase.

There are ongoing issues with the stability of the current website and its connection to other platforms, which have to be managed on a daily basis by the technical team.

The responsibility for the website is divided between the Digital and the Marketing teams. The Head of Marketing is new to the organisation, whilst the Head of Digital has recently been promoted internally. The Head of Content Development has responsibility for the other platforms, but does not have a technical background.

What are three factors that could lead to conflict in this project, and what two ways could you resolve any conflict?

(5 marks)

**11.5** What are two typical causes of conflict within the Deployment phase of a project?  
(2 marks)

**11.6** As a Project Manager, you may experience conflict at various levels, and have to resolve the conflict.

The Thomas Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument or TKI suggests that Low Assertiveness and Low Cooperation is otherwise known as \_\_\_\_ (a) \_\_\_\_.

It also states that High Assertiveness and Low Cooperation is otherwise known as \_\_\_\_ (b) \_\_\_\_.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. Avoidance
2. Competition
3. Collaboration
4. Accommodation

(b)

1. Compromise
2. Accommodation
3. Collaboration
4. Competition

## Exam practice answers

| Question | Answer / Mark scheme                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
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| 11.1     | C                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 11.2     | B                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 11.3     | C                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 11.4     | <p>1 mark for each factor that could lead to conflict, 3 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Division in responsibilities between the Heads of Digital, Marketing and Content Development could lead to different / conflicting requirements.</li> <li>• Division in responsibilities between the Heads of Digital, Marketing and Content Development could lead to disagreement over how to prioritise requirements.</li> <li>• Issues with stability of the website and other platforms could direct resource from the project to BAU.</li> <li>• The Head of Marketing may not have as great an understanding of the organisation as they're new.</li> <li>• The Head of Digital may lack experience in their role, as they have recently been promoted.</li> <li>• The Head of Content Development's lack of technical understanding could cause conflict with other technical resources.</li> </ul> <p>1 mark for each way that conflict could be resolved, 2 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Use the Thomas Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument / Thomas Kilmann to understand different ways to approach conflict.</li> <li>• Use a competing style when there's an urgent decision to be made.</li> <li>• Decide to avoid /accommdate any small issues that don't threaten the project success.</li> <li>• Negotiate between parties to find a compromise.</li> <li>• Encourage the sharing of perspectives / develop a dialogue with all stakeholders.</li> <li>• Facilitate collaboration to explore potential resolutions / focus on a win-win approach.</li> <li>• Keep things neutral / avoid blame.</li> </ul> |
| 11.5     | <p>1 mark each for a typical cause of conflict, 2 marks available in total – any of the below:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Disagreements within the project team on how the solution / project deliverable / project outputs are being delivered.</li> <li>• Misalignment between the project and key stakeholders on progress made.</li> <li>• Commitment may lessen as the project continues.</li> <li>• Agreed processes / methods not being followed by the project team.</li> <li>• Resource availability / commitment may change.</li> <li>• Deadlines being missed / progress not being made according to the project plan.</li> <li>• Scope creep putting pressure on the team.</li> <li>• Technical challenges arising from the solution being developed.</li> <li>• Third party suppliers not meeting expectations</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 11.6     | <p>(a) 1<br/>(b) 4</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |